

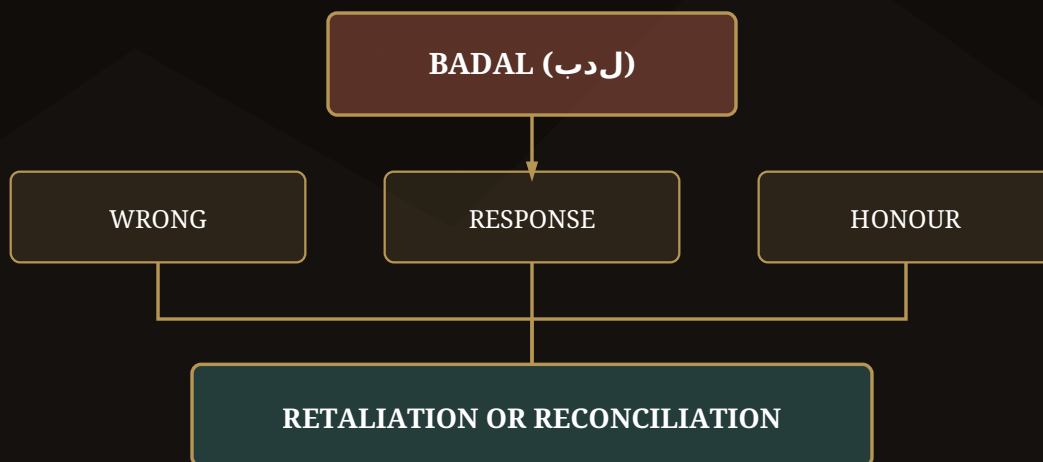
BADAL – JUSTICE & REVENGE

“When the Demand for Justice Becomes a Cycle of Retaliation”

Wrong Injury Demand for Redress Retaliation Reconciliation

Few concepts in discussions of Pashtunwali are more misunderstood than badal (بدل).

It is often translated simply as “revenge.” That translation is not entirely wrong, but it can be incomplete. Within scholarly discussions of Pashtun customary law, badal can refer to retaliation or retribution in response to a perceived wrong, operating as part of a decentralized system of customary enforcement. As Bruce L. Benson and Zafar R. Siddiqui analyze in their economic and legal studies of Pashtunwali, badal historically functioned as a mechanism of accountability and deterrence in stateless societies. Yet it is not a simple command to seek violence; its meaning, application, and intensity have varied across communities and circumstances.¹



“Badal exists within a wider customary world in which retaliation and reconciliation can both matter.”

CUSTOMARY REDRESS VS. PERSONAL REVENGE

Scholars such as Anders Widmark, examining contemporary Pashto literature and cultural memory, caution against treating revenge as a static or simplistic characteristic. While popular representations often depict badal as endless blood feuds, anthropological and legal research emphasizes that customary institutions—such as the thega (truce agreement) and the jirga (assembly of elders)—frequently intervened to mediate, limit, and resolve disputes before escalation occurred.²

REVENGE

Emotion • Personal Retaliation
Unregulated Escalation

CUSTOMARY REDRESS

Responsibility • Redress
Regulated by Custom & Jirga

“Badal operated as a customary system of redress rather than uncontrolled personal vengeance.”

THE DEEPER QUESTION OF JUSTICE

Ultimately, examining badal forces an encounter with a timeless human dilemma: how a community defines accountability when formal state authority is absent or distant. The

wisdom of customary life lies not in romanticizing conflict, but in recognizing that societies must constantly strive to transform cycles of retaliation into durable peace.³

WRONG • REDRESS • RESTRAINT • RECONCILIATION

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

For me, the hardest part of understanding Badal is recognizing why people clung to it. In a world without police courts or state protection, a family had to rely on its own name and strength to deter harm. Yet the true achievement of Pashtun society was never just the ability to retaliate; it was the creation of the Jirga and Nanawatai—mechanisms that made it possible to stop fighting, accept redress, and choose peace without losing dignity.